AGING IN PLACE

Aging in place in Tampa Bay: the benefits, and is the house ready?

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Ask almost any older adult where they want to live as they age, and the answer is the same: right here, at home. An AARP survey in 2024 found that 75 percent of adults 50 and older want to stay in their current home for as long as possible. Aging in place means living in your own home safely, independently and comfortably. The wish is nearly universal. Whether the house can support it is a separate question, and it deserves an honest answer.

Why staying home is worth the effort

Control over daily life. At home, you set the schedule. You decide when to wake up, what to cook, who visits and where the recliner goes. That sense of control is a big part of what keeps people engaged and motivated.

Comfort and familiarity. A home holds decades of routine and memory. Familiar surroundings reduce stress, and knowing where everything is makes daily tasks easier.

Neighbors and community. Many Tampa Bay retirees have spent years building relationships in places like Sun City Center, Apollo Beach and Brandon. The neighbor who notices the newspaper still in the driveway is a real safety net, and it is hard to rebuild after a move.

The catch: most Florida homes were not built for aging

Florida ranch homes look age-friendly because they are single story. In practice, I regularly find:

- A step down into a sunken living room or into the garage, often with no rail
- Raised tracks at sliding doors to the lanai and pool deck
- Glossy tile floors that turn slick with a little water or humidity
- Garden tubs and tub-shower combinations that require a high step
- Narrow hall bathrooms with no room for a walker
- No plan for hurricane season if someone uses oxygen or other powered medical equipment

None of these is a reason to move. Each is a reason to plan.

Signs aging in place may work well

Aging in place is not the right fit for everyone, and your doctor can help weigh the risks. These signs suggest it may work:

- You can manage daily tasks like bathing, dressing and getting around, or the home can be adapted so you can
- Family, friends or neighbors are available to help when needed
- You have reliable transportation, by car or otherwise

- You have a plan for storms, power outages and evacuation

If one or more of these is shaky, that does not end the conversation. It tells you where to focus. For a closer look at the warning signs, see Can my parent age in place in their current home?

How we help

A Home Safety Visit answers one question: can this home support this person, now and over the next several years? A licensed physical therapist evaluates how you move through your own space, identifies what needs to change and prioritizes the fixes, so you know what matters first. You get a photo report and a prioritized hazard list. If you are thinking about moving instead, our Right Home Assessment looks at a new home before you buy.

We visit homes in Hillsborough, Manatee and Pinellas counties, and offer virtual visits in Florida, Ohio and New York. Every service starts with an Initial Consultation, a 30-minute phone call. Current prices are on our pricing page.

Sources

AARP. 2024 Home and Community Preferences Survey

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Every service starts with an Initial Consultation, a 30-minute phone call with Dr. L'HommeDieu.
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